

Latin, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/latin/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Latin volume of a wider project — and it plays a special role. Latin is a **taproot**: the ancestor of the Spanish, French, Italian, and Portuguese tracks, and the single largest source of English’s vocabulary after English’s own Germanic core. Almost every lesson here pays a double dividend — you learn a Latin word *and* you see why a dozen English words, and their Romance cousins, look the way they do.

Latin uses the alphabet you are reading, so there is no script to decode; the work is the words and the **endings**. Latin carries meaning in its endings rather than in word order or helper-words, which is why it can drop pronouns and still be perfectly clear (*agō* already means “I do”). Each chapter introduces that machinery one piece at a time, exactly where a real phrase needs it — never as a front-loaded grammar table.

We use **classical** pronunciation (Caesar’s *v* was a *w*, his *c* always hard) and mark long vowels with a **macron** (ā ē ī ō ū), as teaching texts do, though Romans themselves wrote none. Roots are traced back toward Proto-Indo-European where the trail is clear, and forward into English and the Romance languages — every form supplied in full.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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How Latin sounds — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach the sounds through real words. This page gathers the classical scheme in one place.

The three facts

1. **Every letter is sounded, always the same way.** Latin has no silent letters and (in the classical scheme) no “soft” consonants: *c* and *g* are *always* hard (*Cicero* = *KIH-keh-ro*, not “SIS-er-o”), *v* is **w**, *s* is always hissed (never “z”), and *r* is trilled.
2. **Vowels come long or short, marked by a macron.** *ā ē ī ō ū* are *held longer* than *a e i o u* — same quality, more time. Length could change meaning (*malum* “evil” vs. *mālum* “apple”), which is why teaching texts print the macrons Romans never wrote.
3. **Two vowels together each keep their value** unless they form a set diphthong: *ae* = “eye” (*Caesar* = *KYE-sar*), *au* = “ow,” *oe* = “oy.”

Worth flagging

- ***v* = w, *i* = y.** The consonantal *v* and *i* were glides: *vīnū*... said *WEE-noom* (*vīnum*, “wine”), *Iulius* = *YOO-lee-oos*. The “v as vee” and “soft c” you may have heard are *later*, Church-Latin habits.
- **Stress is predictable.** Two-syllable words stress the first; longer words stress the second-to-last syllable if it is long, else the one before. No accent marks needed once you hear vowel length.
- **No “j” or “w” or “u/v” split.** Classical Latin wrote *i* and *v* for both vowel and glide; the letters *j*, *u*, and *w* are medieval and modern additions.

Latin in the family

Latin is **Italic**, a branch of the great **Indo-European** family — cousin to Greek, to the Germanic languages (including English), and, further off, to Sanskrit. It was the speech of Rome, then of an empire, then of the medieval church and the learned world; as it fragmented in daily use it became Spanish, Portuguese, French, Italian, Romanian, and the rest. That is why this curriculum treats Latin as a *taproot*: nearly every word here has both English and Romance descendants, traced in the lessons.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Latin greetings — and why they matter more than most first words. Latin is a **taproot**: these five salutations are the ancestors of the greetings you met in Spanish, Italian, French, and Portuguese, *and* the etymons of a surprising slice of English’s polite vocabulary. Learn *valē* and you have already half-learned *value*, *valid*, and *prevail*. Each lesson introduces the sounds its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/LA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *salvē* / *salvēte* — “hello” (be well)

Sounds you’ll need

Latin is read as written, every letter sounded. A **macron** (ā, ē, ī, ō, ū) marks a *long* vowel — held longer, never changing its quality. V is like English “way” before a vowel. *salvē* = *SAL-weh*. The classical *v* was a **w**: Romans said *SAL-weh*, not “sal-vay.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Salvē (to one person) / *salvēte* (to several) is the imperative of *salvēre*, “to be in good health,” from *salvus* “safe, sound, whole.” To greet someone in Latin is to *wish them health*. That one root *salvus/salvēre* fans out enormously into English: **save**, **safe**, **salvage**, **salvation**, **salute**, **salubrious**, and the toast “**salut!**” And into the Romance children as the very word for health — Spanish *salud*, Italian *salute*, French *salut* (which became a greeting again, having started as one).

Grammar Lens

Notice *salvē* vs. *salvēte*: Latin changes the *ending* to mark one listener versus many (-*e* singular, -*ete* plural). This is your first taste of the feature that defines Latin — meaning carried in **endings**, not word order or extra words. English lost almost all of this; its Romance grandchildren kept some. You will meet it in every chapter.

1.2 *avē* / *avēte* — “hail” (a formal greeting)**Sounds you’ll need**

Avē = *AH-weh* (again the *w*-sound for *v*). Two syllables, the second long.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Avē is the more ceremonious greeting — “hail” — from *avēre* “to fare well, to be eager.” It survives in English essentially unchanged inside the prayer “**Ave Maria**” (“Hail, Mary”), and stands in the famous salute *avē atque valē* — “hail and farewell” — Catullus’s words at his brother’s grave, pairing the greeting you say on arrival with the one you say on leaving (next lesson).

Why it’s said this way

Avē carried a whiff of rank and ritual — addressed to emperors and gods (*avē, Caesar*). For an everyday “hi,” Romans reached for *salvē*; *avē* was the bow, not the wave.

1.3 *valē* / *valēte* — “goodbye” (be strong)**Sounds you’ll need**

Valē = *WAH-leh*. As with *salvē*, a health-and-strength wish frozen into a command.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Valē (singular) / *valēte* (plural) is the imperative of *valēre*, “to be strong, to be well” — so goodbye in Latin literally wishes you *strength*. The root *valēre* is another English gold mine: **value**, **valid**, **valiant**, **valour**, **valence**, **prevail**, **convalesce**, **ambivalent** (to be “strong both ways”). And the Romance children carry *valēre* as their verb “to be worth” — Spanish *valer*, Italian *valere*, French *valoir*.

Grammar Lens

Three of these greetings — *salvē*, *avē*, *valē* — are the same grammatical shape: a bare **imperative**, a command form of a verb about health or strength. Latin doesn’t say “hello”; it *orders* you to thrive. Feel how the *-ē/-ēte* pair recurs: once you know it, you can address one friend or a whole room.

1.4 grātiās agō — “thank you” (I give thanks)

Sounds you’ll need

Grātiās = GRAH-tee-ās; *agō* = AH-go. The *c/t* before *i* are hard in classical Latin — GRA-tee, not “GRA-shee.”

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

The full phrase is *grātiās tibi agō* — literally “**I give thanks to you**” (*grātiās* “thanks,” *tibi* “to you,” *agō* “I do/drive”). The noun *grātia* means “favour, grace, gratitude,” from *grātus* “pleasing, thankful.” Into English: **grace**, **gratitude**, **gratis**, **grateful**, **gracious**, **ingratiate**, **congratulate**. And straight into the Romance “thank you” you already learned — Italian *grazie*, Spanish *gracias*, Portuguese *graças* — all just the plural *grātiās*, “thanks,” worn smooth by time.

Grammar Lens

Agō means “I do”: the *-ō* ending *is* “I,” so no separate word for the pronoun is needed. This is Latin’s other great habit — the verb ending tells you *who* acts. *Agō* itself is another root you know: **agent**, **act**, **agenda** (“things to be done”), **agile**, **navigate**.

1.5 *ita* / *nōn* — “yes” and “no”

Sounds you’ll need

Ita = IH-tah; *nōn* = nōne, with a long ō.

The word, taken apart — its English and Romance children

Here is a surprise: **classical Latin had no plain word for “yes.”** To agree you said *ita* (“thus, so”), *sīc* (“so, in this way”), *certē* (“certainly”), or simply *repeated the verb* — asked “are you coming?” you answered “I’m coming.” It was *sīc* that hardened into the Romance “yes”: Spanish and Italian *sí*, French *si* (the emphatic yes). “No” is easier: *nōn* (“not”), from older *ne-oenum* “not one thing” — the ancient negative *ne-* that also gives English **no**, **not**, **none**, **never**, and which you will meet again as Sanskrit *na*.

1.6 Recap

Latin		Meaning
<i>salvē</i> / <i>salvēte</i>	<i>be well</i>	hello
<i>avē</i> / <i>avēte</i>	<i>fare well</i>	hail (formal)
<i>valē</i> / <i>valēte</i>	<i>be strong</i>	goodbye
<i>grātiās (tibi) agō</i>	<i>I give thanks to you</i>	thank you
<i>ita</i> / <i>nōn</i>	<i>thus / not</i>	yes / no

Latin greets you by *commanding your health*: *salvē* “be well,” *valē* “be strong.” Those two roots alone — *salvus* and *valēre* — seeded *save*, *safe*, *salute*, *salvation* and *value*, *valid*, *valiant*, *prevail*, and became the Romance words for health and worth. This is the whole reason to learn Latin inside this curriculum: it is the root the Spanish, Italian, French, and Portuguese tracks keep pointing back to, and a root of English besides. Next chapter: *quis es?* (“who are you?”), *nōmen mihi est...* (“my name is...”), and the endings that let Latin drop pronouns entirely.